CHAPTER 10

BURNLEY CC

Cricket is different. There is something about cricket. It is almost as if it takes all of my ideas about sport, these daydreams of who I am going to be, that quiet longing for something else, and holds them all. It says to every aspect of my inner psyche, *We can have you here; we can make sense of it for you*.

My dad is the captain of the Burnley second XI – his father a club cricketer too – and I go to watch them. During the tea break, we drag the bins and plant pots out from by the little pavilion, its purple seats cast-offs from Turf Moor, which overlooks it. They become wickets and extra fielders and we re-enact what we have just seen. At the cricket club, the outside world has a way of muscling into the foreground, lurking and coursing its fingers through everything, as it does in Burnley in general. On the opposite side to the football ground, one-floor houses, some boarded up, look out on to the green, somehow merging with the sight screen, everything the same hue of faded white and grey and blood-red. Set back from them is an old singular cotton mill cutting a shape into the sky. During the off season, to make some money, the pitch is used as a car park for the football, trampled into a sea of flattened grass for fans to use for their convenience, the only remnant being the cordoned-off square for the wicket.

The pitch itself has a ridge in the run-up, making the wicket ripple like a photograph or frozen artefact of the creek that runs over the road not far away, running up and out of the town. There is a slope too. It bears a resemblance to a much more celebrated cricketing slope – the one at the home of cricket – one I have only seen on television and don’t dare even